



Directions

Is there search beyond Google?

Ram Mohan Rao

The word “search” is so loaded, the mind boggles. There are categories of search beyond text—news, images, and so on. There are search engines catering to each of these—as well as to different kinds of text search; in fact, there are hundreds of search engines. Sometimes what you find makes you search for something new—one isn’t even always clear about what one is looking for. The Web isn’t organised; it’s a mess, really, quite like this paragraph. All those neat pages like BBC and Time.com might make it seem otherwise, but think about it: when you’re at news.bbc.co.uk, you might as well be reading a newspaper with a magical sprinkling of interactivity—you don’t need to be on the Internet. You’ll be reading what they present you. The point of the Internet is that there’s (usually) exactly what you’re looking for at some place, and search engines attempt to guide you there.

What follows is our attempt at guiding you to the search engines—to the possibilities.

Meek Contenders

There are, like we said, hundreds of search engines. None of them present you with as many search results as the big ones, but no-one cares whether you get a million results or a thousand: you need just about twenty or so relevant ones.

Let’s first establish why it is that people gravitate to Google (and the others in its league). Is it just out of habit? Because everyone else does it?

Not quite. In this, our look at what might possibly replace the big three, we first looked at www.readwriteweb.com/archives/top_100_alternative_search_engines.php (the URL says it). Forgivably not inclined to perform searches on all hundred, we took a random look: WebBrain.com (interesting name, that’s why). Now people often search for celebrities and models and such, so we took a random name, that of French supermodel Laetitia Casta, and tried it on WebBrain, “The Smartest Way To See The Web”.

It looked good: we got what you see alongside—six category matches, about a hundred “site matches,” and a helpful categorisation of L.C. into “Models and Pin-Ups,” branching out into other models and pin-ups. Smart.

First category match and the first result there brought us what you on the next page. Not quite Laetitia Casta. So we tried another link, and got something equally nondescript.

While we’re still telling you to explore away from the known and trusted, we must say: (a) there happen to be too many search engines that claim new-age capabilities, and (b) the current paradigm—of rating a site based on link analysis—is powerful. You can’t go *too* wrong.

Do explore the page we mentioned: that list is a delight. You’ll find, for example, a search engine you can influence by clicking on feedback links for result pages. (Which is an excellent idea in itself, problem being that enough people need to go there in the first place.)

Now we really want to see if there’s merit to anything beyond traditional search engines, so let’s take a look at Clusty, which readwriteweb.com calls a “Search 2.0” site.

Clusters

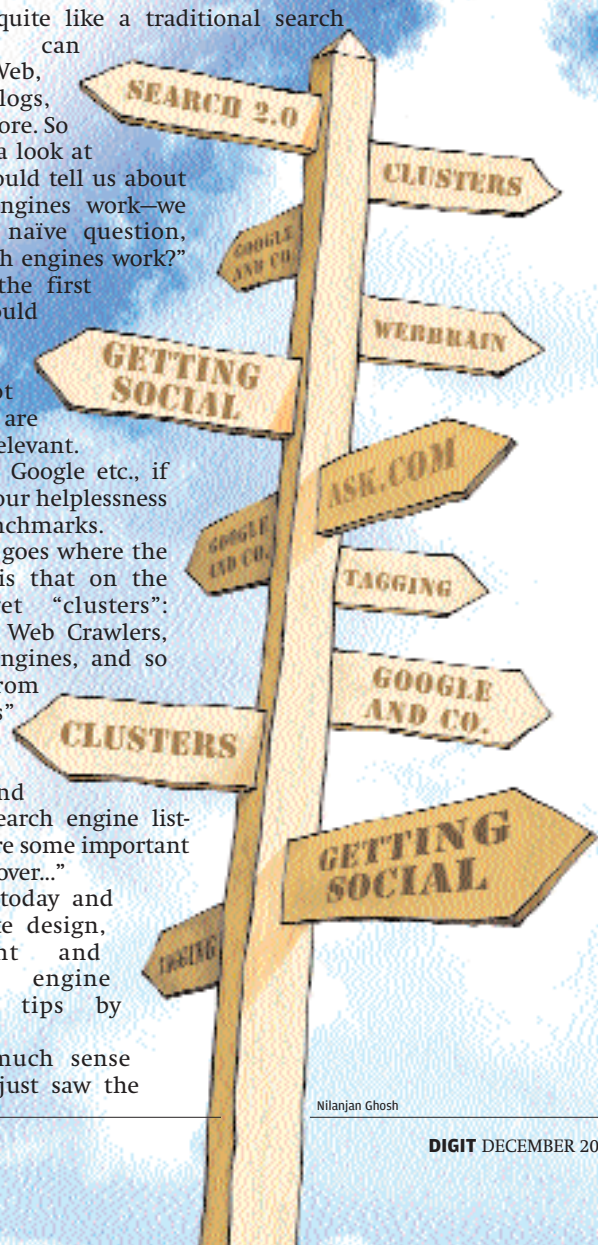
Clusty looks quite like a traditional search engine—you can search the Web, news, blogs, images, and more. So well, we took a look at what Clusty could tell us about how search engines work—we asked it the naïve question, “How do search engines work?” One look at the first ten and we could tell this thing had gotten it spot on: all of them are 100 per cent relevant.

As spot on as Google etc., if you’ll pardon our helplessness in needing benchmarks.

But Clusty goes where the others don’t is that on the left, you get “clusters”: Optimization, Web Crawlers, Meta-Search Engines, and so on. Here’s from the “Tips” cluster:

- ☐ “Do’s and Don’ts of search engine listings. Here are some important tips to look over...”
- ☐ “Subscribe today and get web site design, development and search engine marketing tips by email.”

Not too much sense there. Clusty just saw the



Nilanjan Ghosh